

Romans

Assurances of Christian Faith
Chapter 8

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Paul's Argument so Far...

From Sin and Death to Righteousness and Life

Romans 6

- The believer has died with Christ.

Therefore:

- Sin should not reign.
- Christians should serve in righteousness.
- Not through the power of the Law.
- But through union with Christ and the indwelling Spirit.

Romans 7

- Why can't the Law accomplish that?
- Because the Law cannot overcome the power of sin.
- The Law exposes the **problem** but cannot solve it. (*"Who will rescue me!"*)

Romans 8

- The **solution**. (Romans 8:2 *"Set Free..."*; Romans 8:3 *"God Did It..."*)
- The Spirit provides what the Law never could:
- New life; New power; New desires; Victory over sin
- *"There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus..."*

Christians should serve righteousness

Romans 8

The solution.

"For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death." (Romans 8:2)

What the Law could not do:

"God did..." (Romans 8:3)

So Romans 7 is not Paul's description of the normal Christian life as one of perpetual defeat. It is his explanation of why Law cannot produce righteousness. Romans 8 provides the answer: the believer serves righteousness not through the power of Law, but through union with Christ and the indwelling Holy Spirit.

The cry of Romans 7:24:

"Who will rescue me?"

finds its answer in Romans 8:1-2:

"There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ

Jesus. For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death.” (NET)

The Law in Context

The Spiritual Life Revealed by Contrast to the Law

“For the law of the life-giving Spirit in Christ Jesus has set you free from the law of sin and death.” **Romans 8:2**

Life by the Letter	Life by the Spirit
Depends on the flesh (Rom. 8:3)	Depends upon God's power (Luke 23:49; Acts 1:8)
Produces rebellion (Rom. 7:8)	Produces God's desires (Phil. 2:13)
Results in more sin (Rom. 5:20)	Results in righteousness (Rom. 8:4)
Brings wrath (Rom. 4:15)	Brings joy, peace, production (Gal. 5:22-23)
Not of faith (Gal. 3:12)	By obedience of faith (Rom. 1:5; Gal. 5:5; 2 Cor. 5:7)
Kills (2 Cor. 3:4-6; Gal. 3:21)	Gives life (Phil. 2:12-13)

The Law of the Spirit

A fulfillment of the will and purpose of God

*“There is therefore **now no condemnation** to those who are in Christ Jesus, who do not walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit. **For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has made me free from the law of sin and death.**” Romans 8:1-2*

*“**For sin shall not have dominion over you, for you are not under law but under grace.**” Romans 6:14*

For the Christian, chapter 8...

- Begins with “now no condemnation”
- Ends with “no separation” (compare John 15:1-5)

Romans 8:5-27

- Develops a wide-range of truth regarding the Holy Spirit indwelling the believer.
- Compare to experience of David (Psalm 51) and others regarding presence of Holy Spirit.
- A sort-of “seal of authentication” or “title of ownership of”.

Does the law of sin and death have dominion in our lives?

“In Christ Jesus” John 15:1-5

John 15:1-5

1 “I am the true vine and my Father is the gardener. **2** He takes away every branch that does not bear fruit in me. He prunes every branch that bears fruit so that it will bear more fruit. **3** You are clean already because of the word that I have spoken to you. **4** Remain in me, and I will remain in you. Just as the branch cannot bear fruit by itself, unless it remains in the vine, so neither can you unless you remain in me. **5** “I am the vine; you are the branches. The one who remains in me – and I in him – bears much fruit, because apart from me you can accomplish nothing.

The Righteous Requirements of the Law

How fulfilled?

*“For **what the law could not do** in that it was weak through the flesh, **God did** by sending His own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, on account of sin: He condemned sin in the flesh, **that the righteous requirement of the law might be fulfilled in us who do not walk according to the flesh but according to the Spirit.**” Romans 8:3-4*

How are the “righteous requirements” of the law fulfilled?

- Summary of chapters 6 and 7.
- “That” – purpose clause
- “in us” – not “by us”
- “who walk ... according to the Spirit” [not by our own efforts]
- A statement of fact here; imperative statement in Gal 5:16-17
- The flesh (our selves) will always fail.
- Christ’s purpose was not only to defeat sin (as a man) but also to overcome the sin nature of man.

Galatians 5:16-17

16 But I say, live by the Spirit and you will not carry out the desires of the flesh. **17** For the flesh has desires that are opposed to the Spirit, and the Spirit has desires that are opposed to the flesh, for these are in opposition to each other, so that you cannot do what you want.

The Indwelling Spirit

A phenomenal gift

*“For **those who live** according to the flesh set **their minds** on the things of the flesh, but **those who live** according to the Spirit, the things of the Spirit. For to be **carnally minded** is death, but to be **spiritually minded** is life and peace. Because the carnal mind is enmity against God; for it is not subject to the law of God, nor indeed can be. So then, those who are in the flesh cannot please God.”*
Romans 8:5-8

- “flesh” == human resources
- Contrast is between believers! “those who... set their minds...”
- Emphasizes the impossibility of living under any resources other than the Spirit. E.g. Positive thinking; works; self-denial
- Sincerity is not the issue. It is your mind. Is it focused on the things of the world or on the things of the Spirit...?
- We can’t live for God by human effort! “to be carnally minded is death” (Hebrews 9:14)

The Dual Nature of the Believer

Dead in the body; Alive in the Spirit

***“But** you are not in the flesh **but** in the Spirit, **if** indeed the **Spirit of God** dwells in you. Now if anyone does not have the **Spirit of Christ**, he is not His. And if Christ is in you, the body is dead because of sin, but the Spirit is life because of righteousness. But if the **Spirit of Him** who raised Jesus from the dead **dwells in you**, **He who raised Christ from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through His Spirit who dwells in you.**”*

Romans 8:9-11

- “But” == However
- “Spirit of God” == Holy Spirit (whose mission is? John 16:13-14)
- Every believer has the indwelling Holy Spirit... but...
 - But, is He in control of your life?
 - Do you have the Spirit of Christ in you?
 - Are you in the power of His presence?
 - Do you take advantage of it?
- Romans 6:3-5

John 16:13-14

13 But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all truth. For he will not speak on his own authority, but will speak whatever he hears, and will tell you what is to come. **14** He will glorify me, because he will receive from me what is mine and will tell it to you.

Romans 6:3-5

3 Or do you not know that as many as were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death? **4** Therefore we have been buried with him through baptism into death, in order that just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, so we too may live a new life. **5** For if we have become united with him in the likeness of his death, we will certainly also be united in the likeness of his resurrection.

*“Therefore, brethren, **we are debtors** – not to the flesh, to live according to the flesh. For **if you live according to the flesh you will die**; but **if by the Spirit** you put to death the deeds of the body, **you will live**. For as many **as are led by the Spirit of God**, these are sons of God. For you did not receive the spirit of bondage again to fear, **but you received the Spirit of adoption** by whom we cry out, “Abba, Father.” The **Spirit Himself bears witness** with our spirit that **we are children of God**, and if children, then heirs – **heirs of God** and joint heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him, that we may also be glorified together.” Romans 8:12-17*

What is meant by “we are debtors”...? To whom/what?

- We have a moral obligation to live after the Spirit.
- We have NO obligation to live after the flesh.
- We received the Holy Spirit as a token of son-ship – not bondage.

Are Christians capable of dying spiritually?

- “die” here cannot mean physical death since we all thus die.
- Refer to Galatians 3:1-5; 6:7-8
- Refer to Ezekiel 18:24 (Matthew 12:48-50)

Within this context, what assurances does the Christian have?

Galatians 3:1-5

1 You foolish Galatians! Who has cast a spell on you? Before your eyes Jesus Christ was vividly portrayed as crucified! **2** The only thing I want to learn from you is this: Did you receive the Spirit by doing the works of the law or by believing what you heard? **3** Are you so foolish? Although you began with the Spirit, are you now trying to finish by human effort? **4** Have you suffered so many things for nothing? – if indeed it was for nothing. **5** Does God then give you the Spirit and work miracles among you by your doing the works of the law or by your believing what you heard?

Galatians 6:7-8

7 Do not be deceived. God will not be made a fool. For a person will reap what he sows, **8** because the person who sows to his own flesh will reap corruption from the flesh, but the one who sows to the Spirit will reap eternal life from the Spirit.

Ezekiel 18:24

24 “But if a righteous man turns away from his righteousness and practices

wrongdoing according to all the abominable practices the wicked carry out, will he live? All his righteous acts will not be remembered; because of the unfaithful acts he has done and the sin he has committed, he will die.

Matthew 12:48-50

48 To the one who had said this, Jesus replied, “Who is my mother and who are my brothers?” **49** And pointing toward his disciples he said, “Here are my mother and my brothers! **50** For whoever does the will of my Father in heaven is my brother and sister and mother.”

“For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us. For the earnest expectation of the creation eagerly waits for the revealing of the sons of God. For the creation was subjected to futility, not willingly, but because of Him who subjected it in hope; because the creation itself also will be delivered from the bondage of corruption into the glorious liberty of the children of God. For we know that the whole creation groans and labors with birth pangs together until now. Not only that, but we also who have the first-fruits of the Spirit, even we ourselves groan within ourselves, eagerly waiting for the adoption, the redemption of our body. For we were saved in this hope, but hope that is seen is not hope; for why does one still hope for what he sees? But if we hope for what we do not see, we eagerly wait for it with perseverance.” Romans 8:18-25

What is the glory of 8:18...?

- 1 John 3:1-3 Phil. 3:21

Is the “creation” material? Why personified here? Waiting for what?

What do we, along with the creation, eagerly await? Galatians 4:6

Romans 8:18-25

18 For I consider that our present sufferings cannot even be compared to the coming **glory** that will be revealed to us. **19** For the creation eagerly waits for the revelation of the sons of God. **20** For the creation was subjected to futility – not willingly but because of God who subjected it – in hope **21** that the creation itself will also be set free from the bondage of decay into the glorious freedom of God’s children. **22** For we know that the whole creation groans and suffers together until now. **23** Not only this, but we ourselves also, who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as we eagerly await our adoption, the redemption of our bodies. **24** For in hope we were saved. Now hope that is seen is not hope, because who hopes for what he sees? **25** But if we hope for what we do not see, we eagerly wait for it with endurance.

1 John 3:1-3

1 (See what sort of love the Father has given to us: that we should be called God’s children – and indeed we are! For this reason the world does not know us: because it did not know him. **2** Dear friends, we are God’s children now, and what we will be has not yet been revealed. We know that whenever it is revealed we will be like him, because we will see him just as he is. **3** And everyone who has this hope focused on him purifies himself, just as Jesus is pure).

Philippians 3:21

21 who will transform these humble bodies of ours into the likeness of his glorious body by means of that power by which he is able to subject all things to himself.

Galatians 4:6

6 And because you are sons, God sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, who calls “*Abba!* Father!”

*“Likewise the **Spirit also helps** in our weaknesses. For we do not know what we should pray for as we ought, but the **Spirit Himself makes intercession for us** with groanings which cannot be uttered. Now He who searches the hearts knows what the mind of the Spirit is, because **He makes intercession** for the saints **according to the will of God.**”*

*“And we know that all things work together for good to **those who love God**, to **those who** are called **according to His purpose**. For **whom He foreknew**, He also **predestined** to be **conformed to the image of His Son**, that He might be the firstborn among many brethren. Moreover who He predestined, these **He also called**; whom He called, these **He also justified**; and whom He justified, these **He also glorified.**” Romans 8:26-30*

Is God ever surprised by events? If not, why not?

- Phil. 1:6

Does this passage teach predestination of individual souls to eternal glory? Colossians 1:12-29 “called”; how? 2 Thessalonians 2:13-14

- Refers to what God purposed before creation. E.g. That those who love Him (i.e. a class of people) would be ordained to spiritual union and fellowship with Him. They would look like His Son.

Philippians 1:6

6 For I am sure of this very thing, that the one who began a good work in you will perfect it until the day of Christ Jesus.

Philippians 1:12-29

12 I want you to know, brothers and sisters, that my situation has actually turned out to advance the gospel: **13** The whole imperial guard and everyone else knows that I am in prison for the sake of Christ, **14** and most of the brothers and sisters, having confidence in the Lord because of my imprisonment, now more than ever dare to speak the word fearlessly. **15** Some, to be sure, are preaching Christ from envy and rivalry, but others from goodwill. **16** The latter do so from love because they know that I am placed here for the defense of the gospel. **17** The former proclaim Christ from selfish ambition, not sincerely, because they think they can cause trouble for me in my imprisonment. **18** What is the result? Only that in every way, whether in pretense or in truth, Christ is being proclaimed, and in this I rejoice. Yes, and I will continue to rejoice, **19** for I know that this will turn out for my deliverance through your prayers and the help of the Spirit of Jesus Christ. **20** My confident hope is that I will in no way be ashamed but that with complete boldness, even now as always, Christ will be exalted in my body, whether I live or die. **21** For to me, living is Christ and dying is gain. **22** Now if I am to go on living in the body, this will mean productive work for me, yet I don't know which I prefer: **23** I feel torn between the two, because I have a desire to depart and be with Christ, which is better by far, **24** but it is more vital for your sake that I remain in the body. **25** And since I am sure of this, I know that I will remain and continue with all of you for the sake of your progress and joy in the faith, **26** so that what you can be proud of may increase because of me in Christ Jesus, when I come back to you. **27** Only conduct yourselves in a manner worthy of the gospel of Christ so that – whether I come and see you or whether I remain absent – I should hear that you are standing firm in one spirit, with one mind, by contending side by side for the faith of the gospel, **28** and by not being intimidated in any way by your opponents. This is a sign of their destruction, but of your salvation – a sign which is from God. **29** For it has been granted to you not only to believe in Christ but also to suffer for him,

2 Thessalonians 2:13-14

13 But we ought to thank God always for you, brothers and sisters loved by the Lord, because God chose you from the beginning for salvation through sanctification by the Spirit and faith in the truth. **14** He

called you to this salvation through our gospel, so that you may possess the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ.

*“What then shall we say to these things? **If God is for us, who can be against us?** He who did not spare His own Son, but delivered Him up for us all, how shall He not with Him also freely give us all things? **Who shall bring a charge against God's elect?** It is God who justifies. **Who is he who condemns?** It is Christ who died, and furthermore is also risen, who is even at the right hand of God, who also makes intercession for us. **Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?** Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword? As it is written: ‘For Your sake we are killed all day long; We are accounted as sheep for the slaughter.’ Yet in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him who loved us. For I am persuaded that neither death nor life, nor angels nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present nor things to come, nor height nor depth, nor any other created thing, shall be able to separate us from **the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.**” Romans 8:31-39*

What is the sense of “the love of God” herein? Contrast with John 3:16.

- Galatians 3:26-27; Jude 21

Galatians 3:26-27

26 For in Christ Jesus you are all sons of God through faith. **27** For all of you who were baptized into Christ have clothed yourselves with Christ.

Jude 1:21

21 maintain yourselves in the love of God, while anticipating the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ that brings eternal life.